MEMORY WALK

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ABSTRACT

Memory Walk is a sound and video piece that aims to demonstrate and shape the counterpoint and harmony between perception, memory, and imagination in listening. It is one of a group of pieces that encourage the listener to critically engage with listening in the process of listening to them, made as part of the ongoing PhD project *Listening Music*. This paper discusses the aims of the piece, the project of which it forms a part, and the research process used to test its success at achieving its aims.

1. MEMORY WALK

Memory Walk is a video and sound piece that aims to demonstrate and shape the counterpoint and harmony between perception, memory, and imagination in listening, using the framework of a sound walk as the basis for a critique of listening. *Memory Walk* forms part of the PhD project *Listening Music*.

2. LISTENING MUSIC

The project *Listening Music* is about making sound works that encourage the listener to critically engage with listening in the process of listening to them. It stems from the observation that listening as a concept is extremely difficult to define, and that there is a necessity for the sonic arts to participate in the investigation of listening currently underway in the research community, through the medium of sonic artworks themselves. Summed up as a question, the project asks: How can sound works be made that form a critique of listening?

3. RESEARCH METHOD

To answer this question the project takes sound works that aim to form critiques of listening in the process of being listened to, and subjects them to testing with listeners, using an empirical phenomenological approach to gather data on listeners' experiences(Moustakas, 1994). Before listening to the draft work participants are asked to give a definition of listening; they then listen to the work; and after are asked to give their definition of what listening is, and to describe their experience of the work and what they believed it meant.

Analysis of participants' descriptions of their experiences and definitions of listening demonstrate the effect the piece is having on their understanding of listening, and gives evidence of communication of the piece's intent and other meanings that may arise. Following collection and analysis of listeners' responses, I use my observations to make the finished piece. Through the aforementioned process, the hypothesis that a sound work can form a critique of listening is tested, and the broad variation in possible definitions of listening as a concept demonstrated, further justifying the necessity for the work.

4. DEFINITION OF LISTENING

In the day-to-day context, the word "listening" would appear to have a common sense meaning or set of meanings: it refers to the process of experiencing sound. However, in the field of listening studies, there is ongoing controversy as to listening's precise definition, from Glenn's *A Content Analysis of Fifty Definitions of Listening*(1989) to the present day in Wolvin's *Understanding the Listening Process: Rethinking the "One Size Fits All" Model*(2013). Articles like *Development and Validation of the Imhof-Janusik Listening Concepts Inventory*(Imhof and Janusik, 2006) suggest that listening differs as concept and experience from person to person.

Listening studies researchers are experts in understanding listening as a communication process, artists working in sound are experts in understanding listening as an aesthetic process, both have valid contributions to make in the investigation and definition of listening. Sonic artists already have an extensive history of exploring listening through the invention of modes of aesthetic listening.

5. AESTHETIC LISTENINGS

The most well known mode of aesthetic listening is music. The sounds that are accepted as constituting music seem to have been under revision for as long as music has existed, culminating in Cage's assertion that any sound can be listened to *as music*, identifying music as a mode of listening(Cage, 1961, Small, 1998). However, the expectations that make up musical listening consist of more than an acceptable set of sounds, and cannot describe the qualities of all experiences of aesthetic listening.

The limitations of the musical frame on possible sound behaviour and meaning have led artists to invent other modes of aesthetic listening. These include: Pierre

Schaeffer's acousmatic listening(2004), R. Murray Schafer's acoustic ecology(1994), Pauline Oliveros' deep listening(2005), Trevor Wishart's sonic art(1996), and the currently evolving sound art(Voegelin, 2010, LaBelle, 2006, Licht and O'Rourke, 2007, Kim-Cohen, 2009). In *Memory Walk*, the source material relates most closely to acoustic ecology.

6. ACOUSTIC ECOLOGY

Acoustic ecology is the aesthetic study, preservation, and curating of the soundscape: the overall sound of a particular place and time. A sound walk is a curated walk through a soundscape, in which the walker listens observantly to sounds that under other circumstances may go unnoticed. *Memory Walk* uses the sound walk's mode of listening to critique itself, and other more general features of listening. The term used to describe this process of self-critique is immanent critique.

7. IMMANENT CRITIQUE

To do an immanent critique means to judge a concept using its own method of judgement(Sonderegger and Boer, 2011, Merleau-Ponty, 1962, Kant, 1899). In the context of listening, this means to judge listening in the way that listening judges sound. Listening judges sound events constantly; it judges their identity, and judges the need to give them attention and to act upon them. The theoretical term often used to talk about these processes of listening-as-judgement is schemata.

8. LISTENING-AS-JUDGEMENT: SCHEMATA

Schema, or schemata for the plural, is a term used in philosophy, psychology, and AI to describe the sets of rules by which a thing or an idea is understood to be that thing or idea, its meaning, and actions relevant to it in a given context(Piaget, 1977, Rumelhart, 1980, Leman, 1995, Kant, 1899). I understand a clap to be a clap because I recognise its short sharp attack, rapid decay, its source as a set of hands, and contexts I can expect it to apply to such as a concert.

What is particularly useful about the concept of schemata in doing immanent critique is that schemata not only judge their object, they also judge and refine their own rules of understanding that object. Theoretically this process of refinement of the rules of a schema should be able to be used to force listening to judge itself according to the rules by which it relates to the object of its attention, by presenting an object of listening whose attributes come to make listening subvert the schema for listening in a given context.

9. AIMS OF MEMORY WALK: LISTENING IS PERCEIVING *AND* REMEMBERING *AND* IMAGINATION

Memory Walk aims to question the boundaries between perceiving, remembering, and imagination of future events, to argue that these are co-present elements of the experience of listening; to demonstrate and shape the counterpoint and harmony that takes place between perception, memory, and imagination in listening.

The listener begins in their "normal" listening state with an unremarkable stimulus – the video and audio of walking up the stairs. The second audio recording of the walk, with the video of sitting at the table follows. At this point, there should be recognition of similarity with the walk just experienced, and a comparison of details of these recordings, setting memory against perception. A period of relative silence follows where the comparison of memory can peter out. With the recordings of walking down the stairs, imagination of the walk reversed joins remembering and perceiving, completing the counterpoint between the three modes of intentionality.

In terms of schemata, the listener begins with their normal schema for listening to environmental sound; the piece challenges the rules of that schema by altering the relationship of sound to context and memory, creating a sense of confusion. This confusion can then be resolved either by the listener adjusting the schema's rules to account for what is going on, or by the listener coming up with an alternate explanation for their experience.

10. OUTCOMES

Outcomes of the project cannot be finalised yet as only half the sample group has tested *Memory Walk* at time of writing. However, preliminary data shows evidence that it is successful in its aims. Listeners report disorientation in time during the piece, ongoing comparison and analysis of remembered and heard versions of the sound, and when asked for a definition of listening before and after experiencing it, listeners report a heightened awareness of the role of memory and imagination in listening following experiencing the piece. Although I cannot yet make a final judgement of the piece's success, at this stage it appears major revisions will be unnecessary in the final version.

11. CONCLUSIONS

I can draw the preliminary conclusions that this piece successfully demonstrates and shapes, and produces a heightened awareness of the counterpoint and harmony between perception, memory, and imagination in listening. It also gives credence to the hypothesis that a sound work can form a critique of listening.

Participants' comments suggest that I could make some changes to the piece. For example: two participants who listened to the piece at the site of filming reported experiencing extra layers of memory – of their actual walk up the stairs – and suggested making the piece site specific at other showings for a "richer" experience. One participant reported the poor fidelity and portrait format of the video was distracting, while another reported that this heightened their attention to sound while grounding their experience with some extra sense of reality, so the video element needs further consideration. One

participant also reported a claustrophobic emotional response to the feeling of wearing layers of headphones; this effect may also warrant further investigation.

This has been a fascinating process through which to make an artwork, and as a research method, it appears fruitful and offers many avenues for future exploration.

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